# The State's three forms



Deleuze and Guattari distinguish "three major forms" of the State (459). In fact, they are not stages, since each form is in "resonance" with the others, and all of them "exhibit a unity of composition in spite of their differences in organization and development" (459). The sheet opens the single column that *The five machinic processes* gives to capture. Brackets join the forms where Deleuze and Guattari set out a relation between them.

| Question | The archaic empire<br>MARX'S "ASIATIC FORMATION" | Evolved States<br>EMPIRES, CITIES, FEUDAL SYSTEMS, MONARCHIES | Nation-States<br>MODELS OF REALIZATION OF THE AXIOMATIC |
|---|---|---|---|
| Where is it found? | Egypt, Mesopotamia, the Indus valley, China, and "not only in Asia, but also in Africa, America, Greece, Rome" 427, 450 | Rome's empire (with its consilium and fiscus), the Aegean cities, feudal systems, and absolute monarchy 451-52, 459 | Modern nation-States of every kind (democratic, totalitarian, liberal, tyrannical), as well as the bureaucratic socialist States 455-56, 459 |
| What does it do with flows? | It **overcodes** flows already coded by the communities it rules 427-28, 459 | It organizes "qualified or topical conjunctions of decoded flows" 451, 459 | It realizes "a general conjugation of flows," the capitalist axiomatic 454-55, 459 |
| What is its regime of signs? | Overcoding, "or the Signifier" 428 | Processes of **subjectification** 451 | The **axiomatic**, which deals "directly with purely functional elements and relations" 454 |
| What binds a collective? | The nexum, "the objective, imperial collective bond" 428, 460 | Personal bonds, from contracts between owners to the conventions that tie the owned to their owners 451 | "The Subject that binds itself," a contract "between self and self" 460 |
| | **One moment** of the State through all its forms: "capture, bond, knot, nexum, magical capture" 460 | | |
| What becomes of property? | Everything is public, with the despot as "the sole and transcendent public-property owner" and land that cannot be sold 428 | The public sphere becomes "the shared means for a now private appropriation" 451 | Property is in "convertible abstract rights," and capital is itself "a right" 453-54 |
| What is the form of its law? | "The overcoding of customs" 453 | "A set of topics," subjective and conjunctive (Roman law, cf. Veyne) 451, 453 | The form of an axiomatic, as in the French civil code (cf. Ray) 453 |
| How are persons captured? | Machinic **enslavement**, "generalized slavery" in the megamachine (cf. Mumford) 428, 457 | **Subjection**: ancient slavery and feudal serfdom were already "procedures of subjection" 457 | Social subjection of the "naked" or "free" worker, joined by a new enslavement in cybernetic "humans-machines systems" 457-58 |
| | "A small amount of subjectification took us away from machinic enslavement, but a large amount brings us back to it" 458 | | |
| What kind of surplus value? | Surplus value "of code" 451 | Surplus value "of flow," first among the Aegean merchants and smiths 450-51 | Surplus value that "becomes machinic" with automation 458 |
| What does it do with the war machine? | It has none of its own, working instead through police and prisons while encasting warriors captured from outside 418, 425 | Appropriation proper, as in the hoplite reform's army of citizen-soldiers 419, 426 | Total war, then a worldwide war machine "of which they are no longer anything more than the opposable or apposed parts" 421, 466-67 |
| How diverse is it? | "Little diversity, due to a certain formal immutability" 459 | "Extremely diverse" 459 | A diversity that is "a function of isomorphy," and of heteromorphy or polymorphy 459, 464-66 |
| What escapes it? | Decoded flows of labor and money, and private property "slipping through the net," carried by "the collective figure of the Outsider" (freed slaves, cf. Tökei) 449 | Decoded flows that "draw capitalism in negative outline" but are not let "stream together" 452 | Minorities as nondenumerable sets, and "undecidable propositions" 470-73 |
| | The Aegean "presuppose[s]" the oriental stock, and "there is always an empire on the horizon" 459-60 | | |
| | | "Capitalism was continually being born, disappearing and reviving at every crossroads of history" 460 | |
| How do the forms meet? | "Capitalism has reawakened the Urstaat, and given it new strength." The modern States "restore the most absolute of empires, a new 'megamachine,' whatever the novelty or timeliness of its now immanent form" 460 | | |

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# The axiomatic today: seven givens



In the present, as D&G see it, "capitalism and present-day politics are an axiomatic in the literal sense," which is why "nothing is played out in advance" (461). They set out "a summary sketch of the 'givens'" in seven parts. The last column records where, by their own account, struggle enters.

| Given | ATP | What Deleuze and Guattari say | Where struggle enters |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Addition, subtraction | 461-63 | Axioms are "operative statements." Social democracy adds them (Keynes and the New Deal as "axiom laboratories"), totalitarianism subtracts them, as in "the minimum State of anarcho-capitalism (cf. Chile)" | "It would be an error to take a disinterested stance toward struggle on the level of the axioms" 463 |
| 2. Saturation | 463-64 | Capitalism "has no laws but immanent ones." It confronts its own limits and displaces them at once (oil, nuclear power) | Local struggles must "directly target national and international axioms, at the precise point of their insertion" 464 |
| 3. Models, isomorphy | 464-66 | All States are models of realization: isomorphic at the center, heteromorphic in the socialist East, polymorphic at the periphery | It "would be absurd" to think popular movements condemned in advance, or all States "equivalent and homogeneous" 466 |
| 4. Power | 466-67 | A "power of the continuum" in the military-industrial complexes, where "peace … technologically frees the unlimited material process of total war" | The same capital "continually recreate[s] unexpected possibilities for counterattack" 422 |
| 5. The included middle | 468-69 | The center needs a periphery, and "internal Third Worlds" rise inside the center, with labor split between intensive surplus labor and "erratic" work | Negri's "internal margin," which "tends increasingly to merge the students with the emarginati" 469 |
| 6. Minorities | 469-71 | Minorities (not a demographic count but a fuzzy set) are nondenumerable sets, which States answer by "translating the minorities into denumerable sets or subsets" | The demand "to formulate their problems themselves" is what the axiomatic "cannot tolerate" 471 |
| 7. Undecidable propositions | 471-73 | Not "the uncertainty of the results" but "the coexistence and inseparability" of what the system conjugates and what escapes it | "The germ and locus par excellence of revolutionary decisions" 473 |

| Poles of the capitalist State | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | **Social democracy** Adds axioms by organizing a domestic market and multiplying "directing axioms" 462 | **Totalitarianism** Subtracts axioms and promotes the foreign sector, "the minimum State," with the population "a consequence" 462 | **Fascism** A war economy and "a multiplication by subtraction," a "suicidal" State more than a totalitarian one (cf. Virilio) 462-63, 467 |

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